

PHONOGRAM
THE SINGLES CLUB

KIERON GILLEN & JAMIE McKELVIE

ARTISTS BASICALLY STARVE, AND WRITERS SPEND THE ENTIRE TIME WORKING OUT HOW ON EARTH THEY CAN GET SOME MONEY FOR THE ARTIST KIERON GILLEN

basic £1.19 price will likely reduce over time and the rise of the collector's edition hardcovers ("beautiful fetish objects, essentially"). Both can already be seen in the ComiXology app for the iPad, where books are launching day-and-date with the print books, while DC in particular seems to be veering towards higher end printed collector's editions with its Absolute line. Digital distribution could offer potential creators an entirely new outlet with which to distribute their books, Gillen is undecided on whether ComiXology could've helped *Phonogram*. "Maybe. If we're selling 2,500 copies, we're making no money. In other words, if we sold 500 copies on ComiXology, that would be making more money than we'd make by selling 3,500. However, if you're basically using that as a loss leader to sell the trade, that would be more money than selling 3,500."

The comic-book industry isn't an impenetrable fortress. Like any form of publishing, it is a creative outlet that anyone with the right drive and talent can be a part of. "The most wonderful thing about comics is the fact there's such a low-entry threshold", says Gillen. "Historically, while self-publishing in books is a scarlet letter, self-publishing in comics is a badge of honour. For a long time comics existed in a place where no publisher would take them seriously. If you believed in the work, you published it. All the time you spend not doing is time you're wasting."

Phonogram: Rue Britannia and *Phonogram: The Singles Club* are available from Image Comics, while the first volume can be downloaded via ComiXology. *Generation Hope* and *Uncanny X-Men* are published monthly by Marvel, and are available in all good comic shops.



FUTURE SHOCKS

Writers and artists who'll take over the comic-book industry in 5-10 years

Michael Choi
Occupation: Artist
Known for: X-Force

1 Michael Choi is one of the most exciting artists out there right now. From his very first issue of Top Cow's *Witchblade* to the last, Choi's work has improved tenfold. Having worked extensively for Marvel, his reputation will only improve in years to come.

Matt Fraction
Occupation: Writer
Known for: Invincible Iron Man

2 Fraction has risen at Marvel within a similar timeframe to Gillen; the two even co-wrote *Uncanny X-Men* together until recently. Fraction is currently known for his work bringing Clint Barton and Kate Bishop together in *Hawkeye* and *Sex Criminals* on which he works with artist Chip Zdarsky.

Stjepan Šejic
Occupation: Artist
Known for: Witchblade

3 Šejic's artwork has a flavour of the mid-Nineties style about it, but the fact that it's all fully painted sets it apart somewhat. After an initially well-received run, Top Cow signed the artist up to an exclusive contract to draw *Witchblade* for a massive 35 issues. Work at Marvel soon followed.

JT Krul
Occupation: Writer
Known for: Teen Titans

4 Having produced stories for the independent publisher Aspen, Krul soon found regular work at DC, having launched a new *Green Arrow* title last year and becoming the regular writer on *Teen Titans*. He now appears to have become a mainstay at the publisher.